

HIPAA Privacy Policy & Insurance Eligibility FAQ

HealthFirst Medical Group — Patient Information Document

PART A — HIPAA Privacy Guidelines

What is HIPAA?

The Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) is a federal law enacted in 1996 that establishes national standards to protect sensitive patient health information (PHI) from being disclosed without the patient's consent or knowledge.

What counts as Protected Health Information (PHI)?

PHI includes any information that can identify a patient and relates to their health condition, treatment, or payment. This includes: name, address, date of birth, Social Security number, medical record numbers, health plan numbers, diagnosis codes, treatment notes, lab results, and billing records.

Who can access my medical records?

Your medical records may be accessed by: your treating physicians and care team; healthcare staff involved in your treatment; your insurance company for billing and authorization purposes; and you, the patient, at any time upon written request. Records will not be shared with employers, family members, or third parties without your written authorization, except as required by law.

Can I request a copy of my medical records?

Yes. Under HIPAA, you have the right to access and obtain a copy of your medical records within 30 days of a written request. A reasonable fee may be charged for copying and postage. Requests can be submitted at the medical records department or via the patient portal.

How do I file a HIPAA complaint?

If you believe your privacy rights have been violated, you may file a complaint with HealthFirst's Privacy Officer at privacy@healthfirst.com or with the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office for Civil Rights at [hhs.gov/ocr](https://www.hhs.gov/ocr). You will not be penalized for filing a complaint.

Are telehealth sessions HIPAA compliant?

Yes. All telehealth sessions at HealthFirst are conducted via HIPAA-compliant, end-to-end encrypted platforms. Staff are trained on privacy protocols and sessions are never recorded without explicit written consent from the patient.

PART B — Insurance Eligibility FAQ

Which insurance plans does HealthFirst accept?

HealthFirst accepts most major insurance plans including Medicare, Medicaid, Blue Cross Blue Shield, Aetna, UnitedHealthcare, Cigna, Humana, and most state marketplace plans. Please contact our billing department to verify your specific plan before your appointment.

How do I verify my insurance eligibility?

You can verify eligibility by: calling our billing department at 1-800-555-0177; logging into the patient portal and entering your insurance information; or contacting your insurance provider directly using the member number on your insurance card.

What if my insurance is out-of-network?

If your insurance plan is out-of-network, you may still receive care at HealthFirst. You will be responsible for out-of-network cost-sharing, which is typically higher than in-network rates. Our billing team can provide a Good Faith Estimate before your visit upon request.

What is a prior authorization and when is it needed?

Prior authorization (PA) is approval from your insurance company required before certain services, procedures, or medications are covered. HealthFirst will submit PA requests on your behalf for specialist referrals, elective procedures, advanced imaging (MRI, CT), and certain prescription medications. PA processing typically takes 3–5 business days.

What is my copay and deductible?

Your copay is the fixed amount you pay per visit (e.g., \$25 for primary care, \$50 for specialist). Your deductible is the amount you must pay out-of-pocket before insurance begins covering costs. Both amounts depend on your specific plan. Check your insurance card or member portal for details.

Can I get financial assistance if I am uninsured?

Yes. HealthFirst offers a sliding-scale financial assistance program for uninsured or underinsured patients based on household income and family size. Applications are available at the front desk or at portal.healthfirst.com/financial-assistance. Our patient advocates can help you apply.